Lecture 4: Systems of Government

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: OD ch. 5 (*Governing Institutions in Democracies*)

Theme of the lecture: the **various elements of states and systems of government** — the different types of **executive and legislative systems**, focusing in particular on **parliamentarism vs. presidentialism**.

Lecture frame (FK). *Why it matters:* the institutional set-up **shapes policy** with big downstream consequences for people and businesses, and explains **why democracies function so differently** (US flashpoints the lecture cites: **Citizens United**, **Roe v. Wade**, the **filibuster**). Everything below runs on Lijphart's **majoritarian ↔ consensus** framing + Tsebelis's **veto players**.

OD Ch. 5 — Governing Institutions in Democracies

Book: Orvis & Drogus, *Introducing Comparative Politics*, 5th ed., ch. 5.

Chapter résumé

How democracies organise their governing institutions — **executive, legislature, judiciary, bureaucracy**, and the **national↔subnational** split — and why the same rules on paper produce different outcomes depending on **context** (party number/discipline, institutionalisation). The organising claim: **the executive–legislative relationship** "**more than anything else distinguishes different kinds of democracies,**" giving three models — **parliamentarism** (fusion, Westminster), **presidentialism** (separation, US), and **semi-presidentialism** (dual executive, France/Russia) — judged on **accountability, effective policymaking, and stability**. It sits all this on Lijphart's **majoritarian ↔ consensus** continuum (few vs many **veto players**), then covers judicial review, bureaucracy (the principal–agent problem), and **federal vs unitary** systems.

> ★ **The heart of the chapter:** the **executive–legislative relationship** is what most distinguishes democracies — **parliamentary** (powers *fused*), **presidential** (powers *separated*), or **semi-presidential** (executive *split*). Each is a different answer to **how executive power is chosen, checked, and removed** — trading off **accountability, effective policymaking and stability.**

The red thread. Everything hangs on one question: **how is executive power organised and held accountable?** Place each system on Lijphart's **majoritarian ↔ consensus** line (few ↔ many **veto players**): Westminster parliamentarism = most majoritarian (power concentrated, clear vertical accountability, weak horizontal check); US presidentialism = built-in separation/veto players (strong horizontal check, gridlock-prone). For any case ask: **how is the executive chosen · how is it removed · how many veto players · what's the accountability/efficiency/stability trade-off?**

Key concepts / "modes" to use

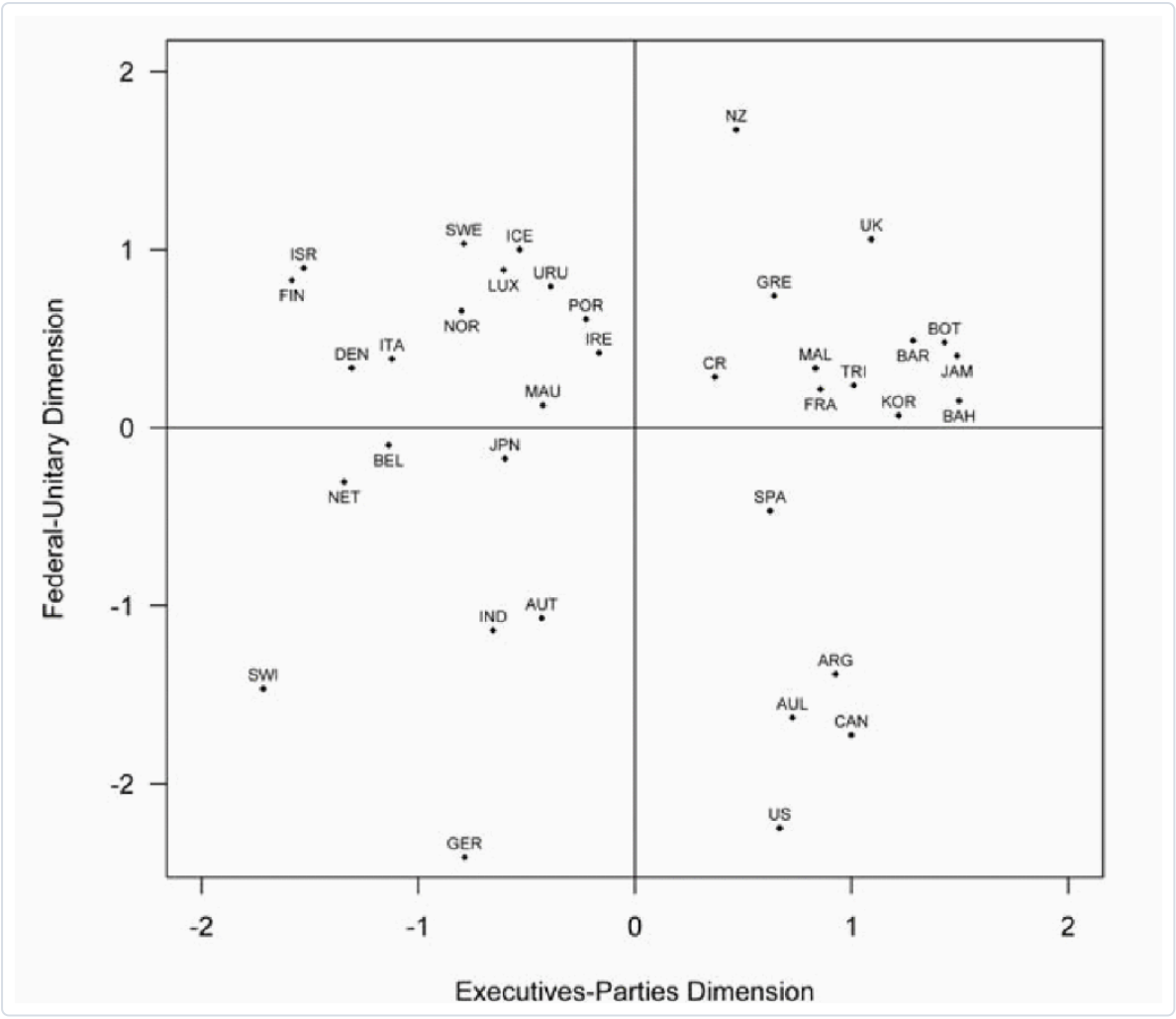
- **Executive** split into **head of state** (symbolic, represents the country) vs **head of government** (runs policy).
- **The three systems: parliamentary** (fusion) · **presidential** (separation) · **semi-presidential** (split executive).
- **Majoritarian ↔ consensus democracy** (Lijphart) + **veto players** (Tsebelis) — the master frame.
- **Vertical vs horizontal accountability** (O'Donnell) — citizens→state vs state→state.
- **Judicial review** (+ common vs code law) · **principal–agent problem** (bureaucracy) · **federal vs unitary**.
- **The stability debate:** Linz's "*Perils of Presidentialism.*"

Section-by-section main points

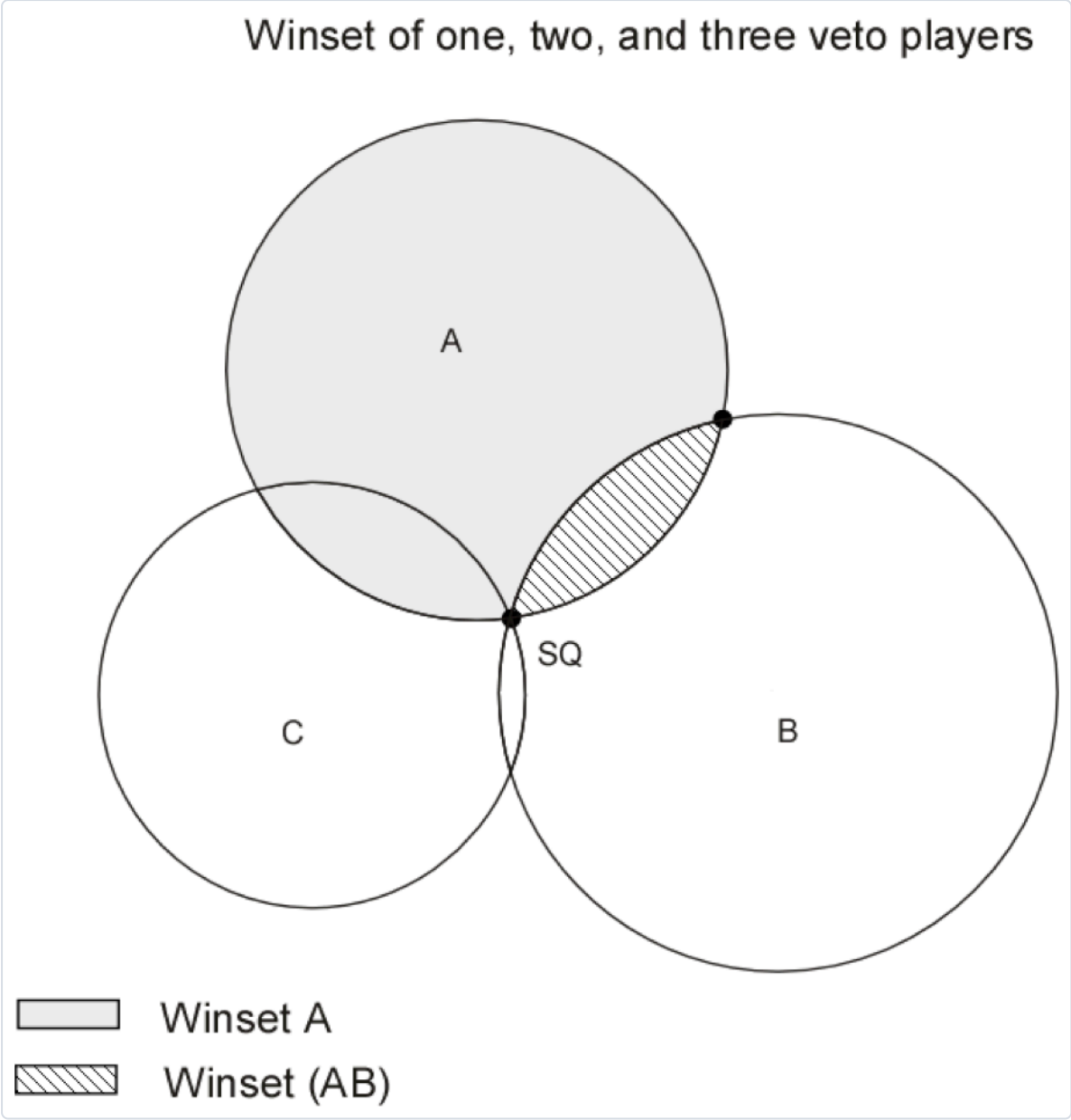
The framing — majoritarian vs consensus, and accountability

Core: institutions differ by **how much they concentrate vs disperse power** — Lijphart's majoritarian↔consensus line, measured by the number of **veto players**.

- **Majoritarian** (UK): single-party executive, executive dominates the legislature, unicameral, easily amended constitution → **few veto players**. **Consensus** (US/Germany): coalition executives, executive–legislative balance, bicameral, rigid constitution → **many veto players**.
- **Veto player** (Tsebelis): any actor whose agreement is needed to change policy — more of them (+ greater ideological distance) = less policy change.
- **Accountability** (O'Donnell): **vertical** = citizens hold the state accountable (elections, ch. 6); **horizontal** = state institutions check each other (this chapter). Only the **executive** is essential to all states; legislature + judiciary exist to *limit* it.



How to read it (Lijphart). Every democracy is a *point* on two axes. **Horizontal = Executives–Parties**: left = **consensus** (coalitions, many parties, balanced exec–legislature), right = **majoritarian** (single-party rule, concentrated power). **Vertical = Federal–Unitary**: top = **federal/decentralised**, bottom = **unitary/centralised**. So the **UK** sits far right (pure majoritarian) but mid-high; the **US** sits right *and* very federal (bottom-right); **Switzerland/Germany** sit consensus + federal (bottom-left). The point: "majoritarian vs consensus" isn't one switch but a *position*, and the two dimensions vary independently.



How to read it (Tsebelis, veto players). Each circle = one veto player's set of policies it prefers to the **status quo (SQ)**. A new policy can only pass if it lies inside *every* player's circle — the **overlap (winset)**. With one player the winset is huge (all of A); add player B and it shrinks to the small hatched sliver (AB); add C and it can vanish. **More veto players (and more ideological distance between them) → smaller winset → less policy change / gridlock** — the mechanism behind presidential gridlock and "stable" consensus systems.

> ★ **Why the majoritarian/PR choice matters for redistribution** (Iversen & Soskice 2006 — from the deck): with three classes (lower/middle/upper), in a **proportional** system the **middle class sides with the lower class** to redistribute from the rich → **bigger welfare states**; in a **majoritarian** system the middle class sides with the **upper class** to avoid heavy taxes from the poor → **less redistribution**. This is a big reason PR democracies redistribute more — a bridge to Lecture 5, and it helps explain the Sweden vs US welfare puzzle.

Executives & legislatures

Core: the executive fills two roles — **head of state** (symbolic) and **head of government** (policy) — and *how those relate to the legislature* defines the three systems.

- One person can hold both roles (US president) or they can be split (UK monarch + PM). The **executive–legislative relationship** is the key variable.
- **Legislatures: unicameral** (one house) vs **bicameral** (two — the upper house usually represents states/regions; standard in federal systems). Legislatures are *more powerful in presidential systems* than in parliamentary ones — because of **separation of powers, a legislator can't also sit in the cabinet**, so members have **no ministerial promotion to earn from the executive** and stay independent. *(In a parliamentary system, ministers ARE MPs, so ambitious MPs toe the party line to be promoted into the cabinet → a weaker, executive-dependent legislature. Note: this is about chasing **cabinet (minister) posts**, not re-election to one's own seat — every legislator chases that.)*

Parliamentarism — the Westminster model *(most emphasised)*

Core: executive and legislature are **fused** — parliament elects the chief executive (**PM**), who is *both* the majority-party leader *and* a sitting legislator. The purest **majoritarian** form.

- **PM is not directly elected:** citizens vote for parliament; the majority names the PM (in practice you know each party's candidate). A **ceremonial head of state** (monarch, or an esteemed elected "president") stays out of politics.
- **Removal = vote of no confidence** → PM resigns (party picks a new leader) *or* asks the head of state to call **new elections**; PM can also **dissolve** parliament. Usually **no fixed terms**. (No-confidence votes succeed only ~5% of the time but signal weakness.)
- **Power depends on the party system:** a disciplined single majority makes the PM "*the most powerful democratic executive in the world*" (legislation passes almost automatically). **No majority → coalition government**, small parties become **veto players**, stability drops (Sweden 2018: 133 days to form a government).
- **Cabinet** of ministers (must be MPs); in coalitions the PM must share out "portfolios" — the cabinet is the main policy-bargaining site and a check on the PM.

Presidentialism — the separation of powers

Core: executive and legislature are **elected separately with separate powers** (**separation of powers**, Montesquieu). The defining feature is *separation*, not that one person is both head of state & government.

- **President is directly elected** and serves a **fixed term**; branches generally **can't remove each other** (only a hard **impeachment**). This builds in **institutional veto players** — lawmaking needs *both* president and legislative majority → checks & balances, but **gridlock** (esp. under divided government).
- **Cabinet** is freely appointed (often non-legislators, any party), subject to legislative consent — but it's a **less important** body than in parliamentary systems. The **legislature is typically more powerful** than in parliamentary systems.
- **Coalitional presidentialism:** with fragmented legislatures the president must build an informal party coalition and act "a little like a PM" (**Brazil** is the classic case).

Semi-presidentialism — the hybrid

Core: executive power is **split** between a **directly elected president** (head of state, with real powers) and a **PM** (head of government, backed by the parliamentary majority, appointed by the president, removable by no-confidence).

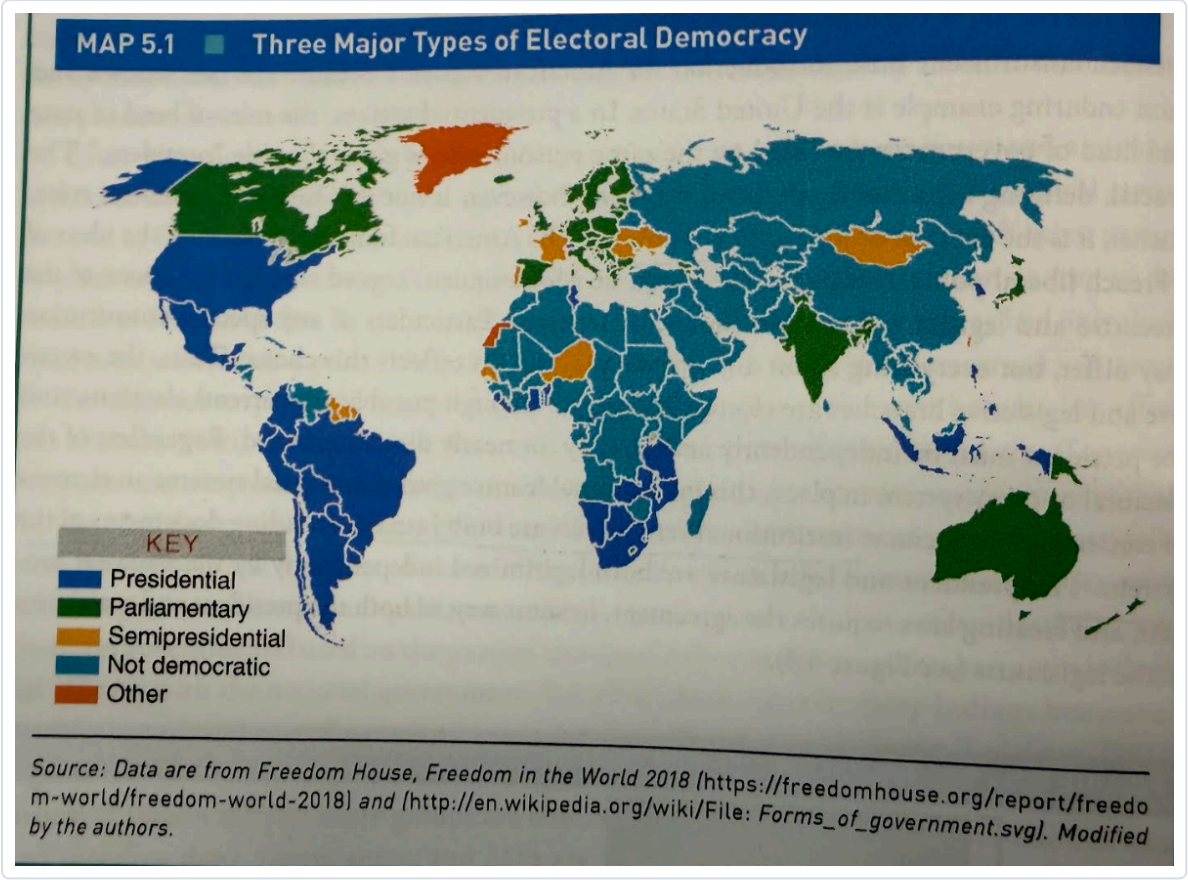
- Legislation needs the president's signature **and** PM/majority support; the powers must be **clearly divided** (often unclear in practice). Originated in **France, 1958 (de Gaulle)**.
- **Cohabitation:** president and legislative majority from **different parties** → president appoints an opposing-party PM (French norm: president runs foreign policy, PM runs domestic). Limits presidential power but can cause gridlock.
- **Elgie's key question:** *can the president dismiss the PM?* If **yes** → unstable, democracy endangered (**Russia**); if **no** → more power-sharing, no less stable than parliamentarism.

★ The core comparison — parliamentary vs presidential vs semi-presidential

Core: learn this table cold — it's the centre of the lecture and the exam.

Feature	Parliamentary	Presidential	Semi-presidential
Powers	**Fused** (exec from legislature)	**Separated** (elected independently)	**Split** executive (pres + PM)
Head of state / govt	Separate (monarch/ceremonial pres + **PM**)	**Same person** (president)	President (HoS, real powers) + **PM** (HoG)
Executive chosen by	**Parliament** (majority names PM)	**Directly elected**	President directly elected; PM by parliament
Terms	Usually **no fixed term**	**Fixed term**	Fixed presidential term; PM depends on parliament
How executive is removed	**Vote of no confidence** (+ PM can dissolve parliament)	Only **impeachment** (hard)	PM by no-confidence; president fixed
Veto players	**Few** (majoritarian)	**Built-in** (pres + legislature)	Depends (cohabitation adds them)
Classic cases	**UK, Germany, India**	**USA, Brazil**	**France, Russia**

- **Accountability:** parliamentarism = clearest **vertical** (voters know whom to blame) but weak **horizontal** under a single majority; presidentialism = strong **horizontal** (separation) but can hurt policymaking.
- **Policymaking (Samuels):** presidential systems **change the status quo less** and more slowly. *Illustration:* **Thatcher (UK) reshaped economic policy far more than Reagan (US)** despite similar aims — she had a compliant majority; he faced a Democratic Congress.



How to read it (OD Map 5.1 — three types of electoral democracy). Colour = a country's system: **blue = presidential** (note how it dominates the **Americas** — the US model spread across Latin America), **green = parliamentary** (most of Europe and the former British Commonwealth), **yellow = semi-presidential** (France and a scatter of others), teal = not democratic, orange = other. The visual take-away: the three systems aren't evenly spread — they cluster by **colonial/constitutional heritage**, which is why the same "choice" of system is really a legacy.

The stability debate — Linz's "Perils of Presidentialism"

***Core:* Linz (1990):** presidentialism is more crisis-prone because of three flaws; but critics say the *society*, not the institution, is the real problem.

- **Linz's three perils: ① dual legitimacy** (two independently elected branches, no democratic tie-breaker) · **② winner-take-all** presidents over-read their mandate and won't compromise · **③ inflexible fixed terms** (a failing president can't be removed). Danger peaks for *new* democracies under **coalitional presidentialism** (small presidential party + fragmented legislature).
- **Counter (Cheibub 2007):** presidential systems just "*tend to exist in societies where democracies of any type are likely to be unstable.*" Semi-presidentialism is empirically **no less stable than parliamentarism** — *if* the president can't override the legislature or sack the PM.

Judiciary

Core: courts interpret law and, via **judicial review**, can strike laws as unconstitutional — making them a **veto player** and a check on the majority (the "why should unelected judges decide?" problem). Only real if **institutionalised**.

- **Two legal families → two review types: common law** (Britain + colonies incl. US; judges follow **precedent**) → **decentralised + concrete** review (*any* court can rule on constitutionality, but only inside a real case); **code law** (Roman/Napoleon; written code only, precedent ignored; French/Iberian colonies) → **centralised + abstract** review (one special **constitutional court**, which can rule on a law in the abstract).



How to read it (OD Map 5.2 — common vs code law). Blue = common law (Britain and its former colonies — US, Canada, India, Australia): judge-made law built on **precedent** → *decentralised, concrete* review. **Green = code/civil law** (continental Europe and its colonial reach across Latin America and Africa): a written **code** is supreme, precedent ignored → *centralised, abstract* review by one constitutional court. **Teal = mixed.** Like Map 5.1, the pattern tracks **colonial heritage** — which legal family a country inherited still shapes how (and by whom) laws get reviewed today.

- **Why let unelected judges override elected majorities?** Defenders: legislatures aren't perfectly representative either; judges are *appointed by elected officials* (Dahl 1957: justices sit within the ruling coalition); courts check the other branches and *claim* to protect minorities (though studies find they more often side with the powerful).
- "**Judicialisation of politics**" (Tate & Vallinder) — courts pulled into ever more political questions; "one of the most significant trends" of recent government, as many actors turn courts into a **veto point**.
- **Independence depends on informal factors + legitimacy:** a **fragmented, competitive** political system gives courts room; judges' own beliefs matter; and because courts command neither army nor purse, hard-won **legitimacy** is what makes review real. *Example:* **Brazil's Supreme Federal Tribunal (STF)** grew confident enough to help impeach presidents and drove the *Lava Jato* anti-corruption probe — but code-law **abstract review** lets **~70,000 cases/year** flood in (≈90% decided by a single judge), making it a clogged **veto point**.

Bureaucracy

Core: every state needs a merit-based, law-bound bureaucracy — but unelected officials with expertise create a **principal–agent problem** (agents pursue their own interests → inefficiency or corruption).

- **Professionalisation** (merit appointment) replaced **patronage** and gives bureaucrats **expertise = their own independent power** — which is exactly what creates the principal–agent gap (agents may expand budgets/turf, or take bribes).
- **Iron triangle** — a cosy, closed policy loop of **bureaucrats + legislators + business** in one sector that serves the insiders and keeps everyone else out (see the Japan case: iron triangles + *amakudari*).
- Controls: **political appointees** (US ~6–8 per department; UK ~2 per ministry), specific legislation, **legislative oversight** (committees, hearings, budgets), courts — none perfect. **New Public Management (NPM)** (Reagan/Thatcher, 1980s): privatise, add competition, "customer satisfaction," flatten hierarchies — a UK 30-year study found a **1/3 staff cut but slightly *higher* costs and slightly *worse*, less-fair service.**
- **Corruption:** two types — **bribery** + **rent-seeking** (using regulation for advantage instead of being productive); worse in **more-regulated, more-unequal** economies (rational-choice), or from postcolonial legitimacy deficits (**Ekeh's "two publics"** in Africa: a moral *primordial* public vs an amoral *civic* one). **Majoritarian** systems (clear responsibility) let voters punish it better. **Johnston's four syndromes:** *Influence Markets* (rich democracies — US, Japan) → *Elite Cartels* (middle-income — Brazil) → *Oligarchs & Clans* (Russia) → *Official Moguls* (poorest).

Federal vs unitary systems

Core: **unitary** = the centre holds sole sovereignty (local powers delegated & revocable); **federal** = sovereignty is **constitutionally shared** with subunits — a built-in way to **limit majorities and protect minorities** (more veto players).

- **Why federate:** bring government closer (big countries); divide power (bicameral upper house + judicial review); protect ethnic/religious minorities (**Belgium** = federalism + consociationalism; **541 days** to form a government in 2010).
- Real power depends on **revenue control** and **upper-house strength**, not paper rules (strong **US Senate** vs weak German **Bundesrat**). **Symmetrical** (US) vs **asymmetrical** (special powers for some units). **Devolution** = reversible decentralisation in a unitary state (UK → Scotland/Wales/N. Ireland). Riker: federalism is inherently unstable (→ centralisation or secession).
- *Examples:* **federal** = US, Germany; **unitary** = France, UK, **Denmark**. In US federalism the **national** level holds war & foreign policy, coining money, admitting new states; **states** hold schools, public welfare, local law & order (the "**Hamilton** [federal] vs **Jefferson** [states]" division).
- **Federalism is only as real as the politics behind it** (revenue + party system, not paper): **Mexico** looked federal on paper but the **PRI** centralised everything via revenue until democratisation (2000) decentralised power to governors; **India** = *centralised* federalism (the centre can redraw state borders or impose "**President's Rule**"), decentralising since 1989 as state parties bargain in national coalitions; **Russia** = a federal **shell** — Putin gutted regional autonomy (appointing governors from 2004; centre took ~85% of revenue). Weak institutions can even preserve **subnational authoritarianism** inside a national democracy (Gibson).

Cases & examples

Why these cases are here — circle them back. Each country shows **one system in practice** — and how the *same rules* give different results depending on the **party system**. Read each for: *which system · how power actually flows · the accountability/stability trade-off.*

Case	System	What it adds
UK	Parliamentary (Westminster)	strongest PM — until Brexit broke party discipline
India	Parliamentary	same rules, different outcome via the party system
USA	Presidential	separation of powers → gridlock; strongest legislature
Brazil	Coalitional presidentialism	strong formal powers ≠ effective power (30 parties)
France	Semi-presidential	the classic case — cohabitation makes it work
Russia	Semi-presidential	dominant president → electoral authoritarianism
Japan	(bureaucracy)	unelected bureaucratic power (iron triangles, *amakudari*)

- **United Kingdom — Westminster parliamentarism.** With a disciplined single majority, the PM is "*the most powerful democratic executive in the world.*" But **Brexit** shattered discipline: May's deal was crushed, parliament seized the agenda, 117 of her own MPs voted no-confidence, she resigned — and **Boris Johnson became PM via a ~160,000-member party vote, no national election**. → *Parliamentarism; the majority-party mechanism (not paper rules) drives PM power; removal via no-confidence + party replacement.*
- **India — same model, different result.** India copied Westminster almost exactly, yet outcomes track its **party system**: one-party (Congress) dominance 1947–89 made PMs *less* constrained than British ones; post-1989 **coalitions** forced constant negotiation (3 PMs in the first 30 years → 12 in the next 30). → *Identical rules → different outcomes based on party number; multipartism pushes parliamentarism toward consensus.*
- **United States — presidential separation of powers.** The Framers feared a strong executive, so the president's *formal* powers are modest (veto, appointments with Senate consent, commander-in-chief); **separation of powers + weak, polarised parties → gridlock**, the norm under divided government (Senate 60-vote rule). Contested workarounds: signing statements, executive orders. → *Presidentialism; built-in veto players; the world's most powerful legislature (Congress).*
- **Brazil — coalitional presidentialism.** The 1988 constitution gives the president **more** formal power than the US president (decrees, line-item veto, budget monopoly) — yet **~30 fragmented parties** (Bolsonaro's own held <10% of seats) force presidents to build **9-party coalitions**, trade pork for votes (often illegally), and still face impeachment (**Dilma Rousseff, 2016**). → *Strong formal powers ≠ effective power; the instability Linz warned of.*
- **France — the classic semi-presidential case.** The **Fifth Republic (1958, de Gaulle)** invented the model: a **directly elected president** (foreign policy & defence, real power) *alongside* a **PM** answerable to the National Assembly (domestic policy). It works precisely because of **cohabitation** — when the president's party *loses* the Assembly, the president must appoint a **PM from the opposing majority** and retreat to their own domain (e.g. Mitterrand with a right-wing PM, Chirac with a left-wing PM).

→ *Semi-presidentialism done "right": because the president **cannot** simply dismiss the PM, the two share power and the system stays as stable as parliamentarism — the mirror image of Russia (Elgie's dividing line).*

- **Russia — semi-presidentialism gone dominant.** The 1993 constitution created an exceptionally strong presidency (appoints PM — reject the nominee 3× and the Duma is dissolved; **decrees with force of law**). **Putin** used it to turn a weak democracy into an **electoral authoritarian regime**. → *Elgie's warning: a president who can dismiss the PM at will removes the incentive to compromise and endangers democracy.*
- **Japan — bureaucratic power.** Japan's elite bureaucracy (recruited from Tokyo University law) drove the postwar boom and often *wrote* the laws, via **iron triangles** (bureaucrats–politicians–business) and ***amakudari*** ("descent from heaven" — officials taking jobs in firms they'd regulated). Scandals + stagnation eroded it; Abe's 2014 reform tripled PM appointment control. → *The principal–agent problem: unelected officials wielding real power.*

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Executive / Legislature / Judiciary	Implements / makes / interprets the law
Head of state / Head of government	Symbolic representative / runs the government
Majoritarian / Consensus democracy	Power concentrated (few veto players) / dispersed (many)
Veto player	Actor whose agreement is needed to change policy
Vertical / Horizontal accountability	Citizens hold state accountable / institutions check each other
Parliamentarism	Exec & legislature fused; parliament elects the PM
Vote of no confidence	Parliament's vote to remove the PM/government
Presidentialism	Exec & legislature elected independently, separate powers
Separation of powers	Constitutional division of power among branches
Coalitional presidentialism	Presidential system where the president must build a party coalition
Semi-presidentialism	Executive split between elected president + PM
Cohabitation	President & PM from different parties
Judicial review	Courts can rule a law unconstitutional
Common law / Code law	Precedent-based / written-code-only
Principal–agent problem	Agent's self-interest may not match the principal's
New Public Management	1980s reform: privatise, competition, "customer" focus
Unitary / Federal	Sole central sovereignty / sovereignty shared with subunits
Symmetrical / Asymmetrical federalism	All subunits equal / some have special powers
Devolution	Reversible decentralisation in a unitary state

Exam pointers

- Reproduce the **parliamentary vs presidential vs semi-presidential comparison** cold — powers (fused/separated/split), how the executive is **chosen** and **removed**, term length, veto players, a case each.
- Explain **parliamentarism** (fusion, PM, no-confidence, dissolution) and **presidentialism** (separation, fixed terms, impeachment, gridlock) as opposite answers to *how executive power is checked.*
- Use **Lijphart's majoritarian↔consensus** + **veto players** to place any system, and **vertical vs horizontal accountability** to evaluate it.
- Deploy **Linz's "Perils of Presidentialism"** (dual legitimacy · winner-take-all · fixed terms) *and* the Cheibub counter — the set-piece stability debate.
- Show that **rules ≠ outcomes**: UK vs India (party system) and Thatcher vs Reagan (policymaking) are the go-to illustrations.
- Know **federal vs unitary** (+ devolution) as a majority-limiting / minority-protecting device.

★ Fun facts & memorable details

> Sticky stats, dates & quotes from Lecture 4 (systems of government).

Quotable / memorable

- Linz's famous article: "**The Perils of Presidentialism**" (1990). Cheibub's rebuttal: presidential systems "*tend to exist in societies where democracies of any type are likely to be unstable.*"
- The British PM with a solid majority is "*often called the most powerful democratic executive in the world.*"
- **Kenya (2013)** switched from a British-style **parliamentary** to a US-style **presidential** system with its new constitution — a live natural experiment.

Striking numbers

- **Belgium 2010:** a **world-record 541 days** to form a government; **Sweden 2018:** 133 days.
- Votes of no confidence **succeed ~5% of the time.**
- **Boris Johnson** became PM chosen by **fewer than 160,000** Conservative members — no national election.
- **India:** 3 PMs in 1947–77 → **12** in 1977–2007 (multipartism = less stability).
- **Brazil:** 30 parties in the Chamber; presidential coalitions average **9 parties**; **60% of Congress under indictment** in 2016.
- **US Senate:** representatives of just over **10%** of the population can block a bill (60-vote rule); state representation ratio ≈ **66:1**.
- **Semi-presidentialism** spread from **10 (1990) → 52 (2018)** systems; 16 are former French/Portuguese colonies.
- **Federal** countries ≈ **25**, but hold **>40% of the world's population**; 7 of the 10 largest countries by area are federal.

Thinkers to name-drop

- Separation of powers ← **Montesquieu** · semi-presidentialism ← **France 1958 / de Gaulle** · code law ← **Napoleon** · majoritarian/consensus ← **Lijphart** · veto players ← **Tsebelis** · vertical/horizontal accountability ← **O'Donnell** · federalism-as-bargain ← **Riker.**
